

CHRIST

THE IDEAL STOIC

Stoicism gives us a vision, Christ gives us a face



JAY SAENZ, MD

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The Ideal Stoic: Beyond Stoicism to the Person of Christ

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Introduction

*To be what we are,
and to become what we are capable of becoming,
is the only end of life.*

—BARUCH SPINOZA

JESUS CHRIST IS the most studied figure in human history, yet one aspect of his character has remained quietly under-examined: his remarkable alignment with the ideals of an ancient philosophy, Stoicism. His words and works have been analyzed from every conceivable angle, yet through this lens something newly illuminating emerges. His life reveals a profound harmony of wisdom, courage, and temperance—the steady virtues Stoic philosophers once only imagined could fully coexist in a single soul.

To begin illustrating the point, let me offer you a quote from Seneca (4 BC–AD 65) in which he describes what the ideal Stoic

looks like. As you read it, I invite you to keep in mind whatever you already know about Jesus Christ.

If you see a man who is unterrified in the midst of dangers, untouched by desires, happy in adversity, peaceful amidst the storm, who looks down upon men from a higher plane, and views the gods on a footing of equality, will not a feeling of reverence for him steal over you, will you not say: "This quality is too great and too lofty to be regarded as resembling this petty body in which it dwells? A divine power has descended upon that man." When a soul rises superior to other souls, when it is under control, when it passes through every experience as if it were of small account, when it smiles at our fears and at our prayers, it is stirred by a force from heaven. A thing like this cannot stand upright unless it be propped by the divine. Therefore, a greater part of it abides in that place from whence it came down to earth. Just as the rays of the sun do indeed touch the earth, but still abide at the source from which they are sent; even so the great and hallowed soul, which has come down in order that we may have a nearer knowledge of divinity, does indeed associate with us, but still cleaves to its origin; on that source it depends, thither it turns its gaze and strives to go, and it concerns itself with our doings only as a being superior to ourselves.³

³ Lucius Annaeus Seneca, *Letters from a Stoic*, trans. Richard M. Gummere (n.p.: Pantianos Classics, n.d.), 57, Letter 41.

Few ancient writers describe moral greatness so vividly. With these words, Seneca seems to anticipate the life of Christ.

Christ Through a Stoic Lens

If you are a Christian, it is difficult to read Seneca's words without hearing an echo of the Incarnation. The reverence for a man who "has come down in order that we may have nearer knowledge of divinity" sounds unmistakably like the Christian story itself. The reflections that follow should be thought of less as theological treatises and more as moral meditations. And while they are approached from a Christian perspective, they are written to be accessible whether one approaches Christ as divine or as an exemplar of human virtue.

For those less familiar with Seneca, he was a Roman philosopher, statesman, and Stoic giant. He shaped much of what we know about Stoicism through his letters and essays. In these writings, he describes in meticulous detail the character and conduct of the ideal Stoic. Seneca's words and ideas will form much of the content of this book. Over years of reading him, I found myself struck repeatedly by how his highest moral vision seemed to converge with the character of Christ. This book is the result of reflecting on that alignment.

Seneca and Christ were, remarkably, near contemporaries and may have lived in the same decades. The Gospel accounts were written well after Seneca's death, however. One interesting historical note is that Seneca's brother appears in the book of Acts, and that Seneca, along with the apostles Peter and Paul, was sentenced to death by the Roman emperor Nero. Even so, it is unlikely that he

knew much, if anything, about Jesus. And yet his description of the ideal man bears an uncanny resemblance to Christ.

Examining Christ's life through a Stoic lens does not diminish him. To the contrary, it magnifies the practical depth of his example. It is not an effort to reduce him to a philosopher, but to show how fully he embodies, and ultimately surpasses, the ideal. The value of having someone to emulate is something Seneca championed himself:

Cherish some man of high character, and keep him ever before your eyes, living as if he were watching you, and ordering all your actions as if he beheld them.⁴

He believed the imagined presence of an admirable man would improve our character. For Seneca, this was simply practical:

We can get rid of most sins, if we have a witness who stands near us when we are likely to go wrong. The soul should have someone whom it can respect—one by whose authority it may make even its inner self more refined.⁵

Seneca regularly pointed to the lives of great men as living examples of virtue. Had Seneca known Jesus, I suspect he might have seen in him the living example of the virtues he described.

The task of reconciling Christ's teachings with prevailing philosophies is not new. Augustine blended Cicero with Christ and Aquinas did the same with Aristotle. This book stands within that long

⁴ Seneca, *Letters from a Stoic*, 19, Letter 11.

⁵ Seneca, *Letters from a Stoic*, 19, Letter 11.

tradition of bringing Christ into conversation with the best insights of classical thought.

The Divine Source of Strength

At first glance, Stoicism can appear to be a project of self-mastery achieved solely through human reason. That impression, however, misses something essential. Even the Stoics did not believe that goodness could exist apart from divine help. Seneca wrote:

No man can be good without the help of God. Can one rise superior to fortune unless God helps him to rise?⁶

This alignment points to what theologians call common grace—the idea that the same God who reveals himself in scripture also illuminates the minds of all people through conscience and reason. In this light, Stoic self-discipline is not a rejection of God’s help but a rigorous cooperation with it. While we explore the deeper mechanic of this spiritual transformation in the chapters to come, we begin with the conviction that all true virtue is ultimately grace in action.

In this light, Stoic self-discipline can rightfully be seen not as a rejection of God’s help but as a cooperation with it. The Stoic’s “spark of the divine” and the Christian’s “indwelling Spirit” point to distinct but related realities. Seneca’s reasoning led him astonishingly close to what Christians later called sanctification—a moral transformation sustained by divine assistance.

⁶ Seneca, *Letters from a Stoic*, 58, Letter 41.

When this book speaks of inner work and moral formation (whether from a Stoic or Christian perspective), it does not imply independence from God, but rather participation in divine sustaining grace. What the Stoics, and Seneca in particular, grasped by reason, Christ revealed in fullness: that all true virtue, all genuine goodness, is grace in action. It is the quiet work of God within the human soul.

The Stoic Lens Explained

If grace empowers the inner work, the question arises: What exactly is that work? Before turning to practice itself, we need to address a common misunderstanding. Stoicism is not a rejection of emotion, but a mastery of it. As Seneca wrote:

Our wise man feels his troubles but overcomes them.⁷

Feelings are not eliminated. They are reordered to reason and aligned with virtue. Stoicism is not coldness, but composure. Christ himself displayed compassion, grief, and righteous anger, but he never surrendered to impulse. His emotions were not suppressed but rightly ordered. Because his emotions were shaped by truth and governed by wisdom, he embodied what the Stoics could only describe.

At its heart, Stoicism is a philosophy of perception. It is a discipline that refines how we see and interpret the world. It teaches that emotions arise not from events themselves, but because of the opinions we form about them. An event in and of itself can be

⁷ Seneca, *Letters from a Stoic*, 14, Letter 8.

seen as neutral. The emotions we feel are born of judgment, not circumstance. We cannot control the event, nor our first emotional impulse, but we can govern the values and beliefs that shape our judgments. Nietzsche, no friend of Stoicism or Christianity, nevertheless acknowledged this same truth when he wrote:

Behind feelings stand judgments and evaluations which we inherit in the form of feelings. The inspiration born of a feeling is the grandchild of a judgment—and often a false judgment!⁸

Marcus Aurelius emphasized that we can also choose to have no opinion at all. All strong opinions are burdens we carry. The Stoics admonish us to make sure they are worth the price we pay to do so.

The Stoic project is the continual labor of clarifying our vision, of learning to align the will with what our conscience affirms as good. The Stoics understood that while the world lies beyond our control, the soul does not.

Here the Christian finds familiar ground. The apostle Paul echoes this truth when he writes:

Be transformed by the renewing of your mind.⁹

Both the Stoic and the Christian locate peace in the renewal of beliefs. To live under the rule of impulsive emotion is a form of self-imposed tyranny. Liberation lies in the reformation of the mind.

⁸ Friedrich Nietzsche, *Daybreak: Thoughts on Prejudices of Morality*, trans. R. J. Hollingdale (Cambridge University Press, 1997), §35.

⁹ Romans 12:2 (ESV).

What we see in the work of Seneca and the other Stoics is a kindred discipline to that of the practicing Christian. It is not a rival to faith but a complement to the work of cultivating it. Stoic thought gives structure to the process of transformation, showing, step by step, how virtue is formed. Both Stoicism and Christianity encourage movement to a similar end—a mind governed by truth, a life ordered by virtue, and a heart at peace.

The Ideal Stoic

The premise of the book is not that Christ aligns with Stoicism but that Stoicism, at its highest and best, echoes the deeper truths that Christ embodied in full. Through reason and discipline, the Stoics observed qualities eternally valuable: humility, self-mastery, temperance, and virtue. They discovered fragments of a deeper law embedded in the human spirit and written on the human heart. Christ did not discover their standard; he was the standard. The virtues the philosophers sought to attain, he embodied in full.

The premise of the book is that in Christ, the abstract becomes personal and the ideal becomes incarnate. Seneca, Aurelius, Epictetus, and other Stoic philosophers found pieces of the truth, but Christ revealed the whole. The goal here isn't to elevate Christ by comparing him to Stoicism; it is to show that wherever Stoicism speaks truly, it does so by reflecting the standard that is Christ. In what follows, we'll explore how the pursuit of virtue, reason, and composure finds its clearest expression in him.

Virtue, Not Happiness

One of the central claims of this book is that happiness, at least as it is commonly understood, is the wrong thing to pursue. It is an elusive feeling too fleeting and too dependent on circumstance to serve as life's highest aim. Happiness should not be our goal. Virtue should. In the course of that pursuit, we find we have stumbled upon something that searching for happiness could never provide: steady fulfillment and durable peace. And then we realize that is what we wanted all along. The emotion we call happiness is constrained by temperament, circumstance, and even the chemistry of the brain. Peace and fulfillment, however, are not exhausted by such things. A life spent pursuing virtue is not guaranteed happiness at every moment, but it is far more likely to be accompanied by an abiding sense of spiritual wholeness.

The Path Forward

As a husband, father, and physician, I've often felt the strain of divided attention and the need to bring what I believe into closer alignment with how I live. My aim is to gather ideas you may already recognize and bring them into a coherent vision of life—one marked by purpose, contribution, virtue, and peace. I hope these reflections will not only clarify the path, but strengthen your desire to walk it.

The fulfillment we want lies on the far side of rigorous personal development. And the path leading there—the one that weaves through modern distractions, self-absorption, and suffering—has already been forged. My aspiration is to help both you and me see it more clearly and take it more often.

The chapters that follow examine the virtues the Stoics most revered and show how they find their clearest and highest expression in Christ. My purpose is not merely to compare two moral traditions, but to offer a more coherent vision of human formation and a more compelling picture of the life we are called to live. If the Stoics help us see the outline of human excellence, Christ gives us its living face. With a clearer picture of virtue in action, I hope you will be equipped and inspired to, as Seneca urges, “rise to a higher life.”¹⁰

¹⁰ Seneca, *Letters from a Stoic*, 35, Letter 22.

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FOR CENTURIES, the Stoics taught that a well-ordered mind could steady us through chaos. Wisdom, courage, temperance, and justice could anchor the soul no matter what life demanded. Marcus Aurelius reflected on these virtues in his journal. Seneca explored them in his letters. Epictetus embodied them in hardship. Yet for all their brilliance, the Stoics were describing an ideal they could point to but never fully embody.

Christ the Ideal Stoic is Jay Saenz's compelling answer to that unfinished vision.

Drawing on decades as an orthopedic surgeon, husband, father, and entrepreneur, Saenz argues that the Stoics did more than invent a philosophy of virtue. They glimpsed enduring truths about human flourishing. What they perceived in fragments, Christ embodied completely. The sage they sought is found not in abstract principles, but in the life of Christ.

Moving through wisdom, courage, temperance, humility, peace, joy, and sacrificial love, the book shows how the life of Christ gives flesh and blood to the virtues the Stoics so deeply admired. Rather than diminishing Stoicism, Saenz reveals how its highest aspirations find their fullest expression in Christ.

Written for readers seeking greater resilience, clarity, and purpose, this is more than philosophical insight. It offers a practical vision for cultivating enduring character amid the pressures and uncertainties of modern life.

Stoicism gives us a vision. Christ gives us a face.

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